

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1994-08-01

To an individual b ahá'í

1 dear b ahá'í f riend,
2 your letter of 18 july 1994 has been received by the universal house of
3 justice, which has asked us to send the following reply. . . .

you have asked how you can “overcome [your] view of the faith as

4 flawed.” your comment correctly locates the difficulty, which inheres not
5 in the faith, in itself perfect, but in the inability of the finite human mind 186.2

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187 .2

188 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

189 08to fully grasp the import and perfection of the Teachings. given the tre-

190 mendous variety of culture and individual type, it should be clear upon

191 reflection to any fair-minded observer that the revelation of god cannot

192 accord with all of the theories, whims and desiderata of mankind, which are

193 in a constant state of flux and are the product of limited human aspirations, very
often corrupted by selfish motives. Nor could it possibly be true that

194 the revelation as a whole would necessarily appear to a given observer to be

195 in every way a perfect tapestry, according with one's subjective concepts of

196 beauty, elegance, coherence, order, rationality, etc.

197 Thus, it would not be surprising if, during the course of one's life and

198 as one's understanding and perspective evolves, from time to time one finds aspects
of the faith that seem in conflict with one's best understanding,

199 particularly insofar as that understanding is informed by the broader society

200 or culture around oneself. how one responds to such episodes is of critical

201 importance to the maintenance of one's faith. The task is to seek a larger
 202 context in which to understand the issue which is disturbing and to seek to
 prayerfully accept what one cannot for the time being understand. This is
 203 different from adopting an antirational or romantic posture whereby one
 204 believes in all sorts of nonsense. quite to the contrary, what one is doing in
 205 such a case is accepting the Teachings of one whose authority is acknowl-
 206 edged to be from god. This is the light of faith which enables a believer to
 207 weather difficult situations in which he cannot see his way clearly by the light of
 reason alone. it is an attitude which flows from a recognition of the
 208 finite nature of one's own mind and the inevitable limitations of one's expe-
 209 rience. bahá'u'lláh himself urges us in the hidden words to "p ass beyond
 210 the baser stages of doubt and rise to the exalted heights of certainty."
 211 187-1

consider, when one looks about at the world and at the condition into

212 which its peoples have fallen and the untold agony of human suffering, what could
 have caused such a lamentable state of affairs? i s it not a fair assump-
 213 tion that the reigning materialist worldview, with its inordinate emphasis
 214 on individual liberty and its discounting of ordering norms and mores, is at least
 partly to blame? Again, in Gleanings, bahá'u'lláh writes: "r egard men

as a flock of sheep that need a shepherd for their protection."

215 187-2 he also
 216 admonishes us:
 217 187-1. hw , persian, no. 9.
 218 187-2. gwb, no. 159.3.187 .3
 187 .4
 188 1993–1996 • T h e T h r e e Y e a r P l a n

09regard the world as the human body which, though at its creation

whole and perfect, hath been afflicted, through various causes, with

189 grave disorders and maladies. Not for one day did it gain ease, nay its
 190 sickness waxed more severe, as it fell under the treatment of ignorant physicians,
 who gave full rein to their personal desires, and have erred grievously. And if, at one time,
 through the care of an able physician,

a member of that body was healed, the rest remained afflicted as be-

191 fore. Thus informeth you the All-knowing, the All-wise.

192 187-3

193 if one extends this line of thinking yet a little further, is it not conceiv-

194 able that many, if not most, of those who mould public opinion on issues

195 such as sexuality are themselves steeped in a climate of thinking which in-

196 fluences and biases their reading of scientific evidence? To what degree then, one might ask, does this climate of opinion color the way one perceives the revelation itself? This argument is suggested to you as a stimulus to your

197 thinking as you grapple with the problem referred to in your letter. The intent is not to cast general aspersions on the entire scientific community or to suggest that there are not many reliable and clear-thinking leaders of public opinion.

A few things which one encounters in the Teachings do not lend them-

198 selves to rational analysis at all, but must be accepted in a spirit of deep faith. The ineligibility of women for service on the universal house of

199 justice is one such instance. however, here again, the important thing is to

200 view this fact within the larger context of what our Teachings actually say about the role of women and the role of men.

201 As you strive to acquire a fuller understanding of the Teachings, be as-

202 sured of the loving prayers of the house of justice in the holy Shrines on

203 your behalf.

204 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

Department of tHe secretariat

205 187-3. gwb, no. 120.1.187 .4a

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188 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

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Message to the World Forestry Charter Gathering

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]